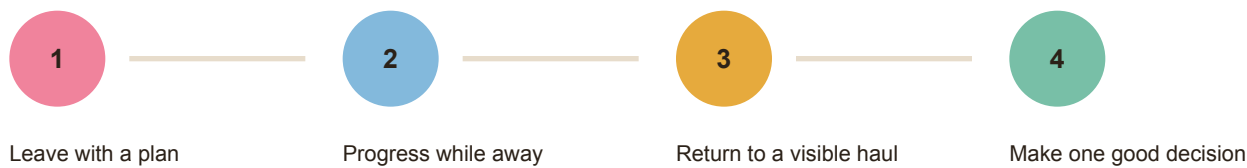


iOS Idle Games: What Still Works in 2026

From the discontinued Temple Run: Idle Explorers to today's largest tycoon, cozy, RPG and pure-incremental references.

THE DURABLE LOOP



Prepared for Tickle the Pig

U.S. App Store snapshot | August 3, 2026

12 reference profiles | product patterns | TTP recommendations

The genre is not passive. It is delayed authorship.

The best idle games let time do the labor, then reserve the emotionally important decision for the player.

01

The world must visibly change

Egg, Inc., Cats & Soup and Idle Miner turn arithmetic into chickens, cats, facilities and staffed production lines. Seeing the machine grow is the reward.

02

A close goal lives inside a huge horizon

The next venue, planet, boss or prestige breakpoint is legible now; the full account can keep expanding for months.

03

Return is a ceremony, not an inbox

A useful return screen explains where the character went, what happened, what came home and which choice matters next.

04

Active play accelerates the promise

Idle Breaker and Tap Titans add tactile verbs, but durable systems keep offline time meaningful. Active play should never make the idle path feel fake.

05

Live ops can become the product's tax

Events, passes, clans and side modes retain players until currencies and chores obscure the core fantasy. System count is a design budget.

Bottom line for TTP. Rosie's Ramble should sit closer to Cats & Soup + Idle Planet Miner than to a dense gacha RPG: one lovable pig, one visible road, one small loadout decision, one warm return, and one pooled Sounder goal.

A mature genre with several very large iOS incumbents

U.S. rating counts are a directional reach proxy - not downloads, revenue, or monthly active users. Bars use a logarithmic scale so smaller references remain visible.

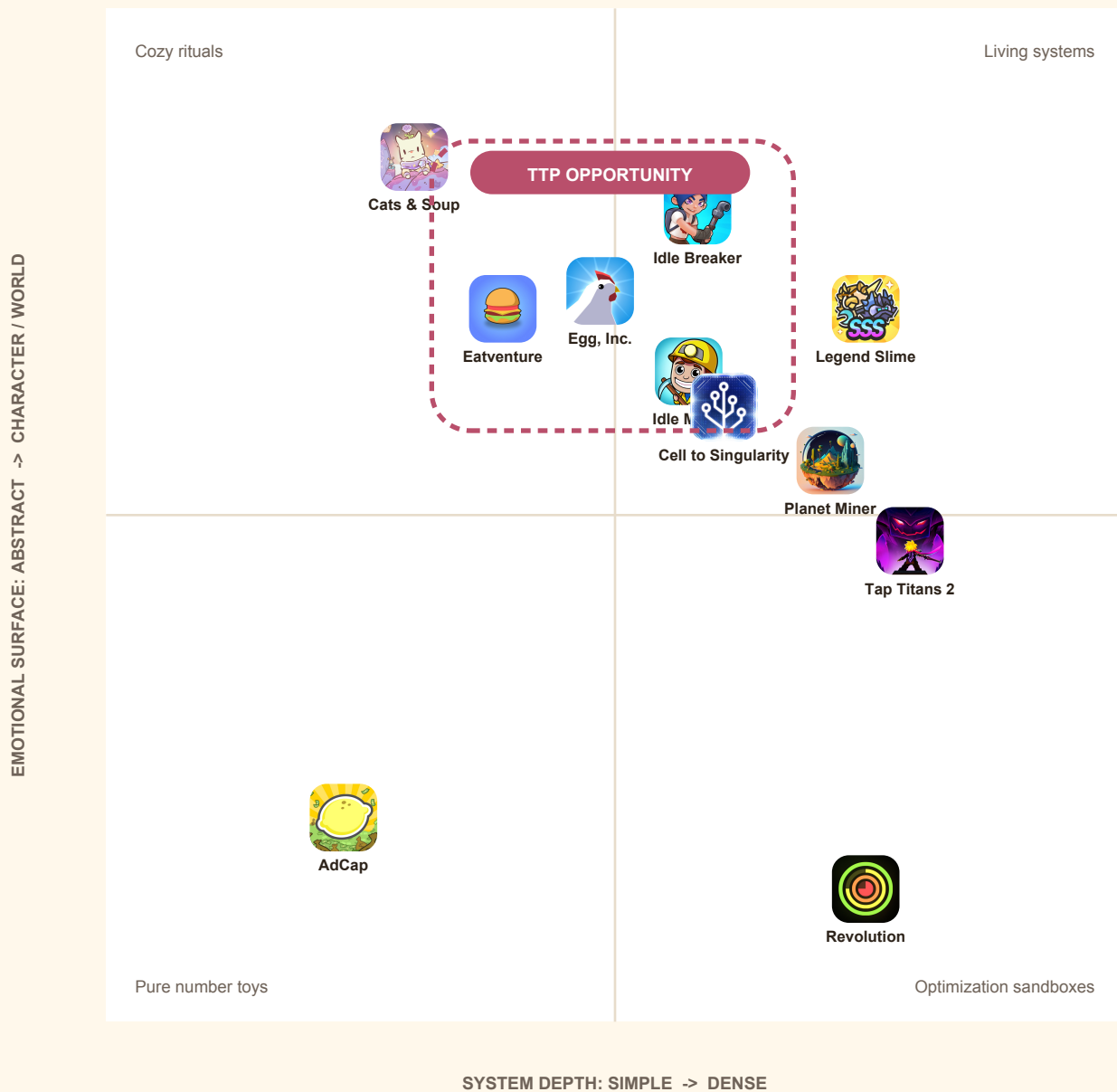


TITLE CHECK

Temple Run: Idle Explorers is no longer an active benchmark. Imangi removed it from stores on October 11, 2024 and shut its servers on November 8, 2024. The similarly named Madbox game Idle Explorer is a separate, lightly rated title. [S0, S12]

Two axes explain most of the meaningful design differences

A game can be mechanically deep without feeling alive, or visually warm without offering meaningful authorship. TTP's opportunity is the upper-middle: warm world, restrained systems.



Exploration and the classic tycoon spine



HISTORICAL EXPLORER

Temple Run: Idle Explorers [S0]

Released 2023 | removed Oct 2024 | servers closed Nov 2024

Loop. Choose familiar Temple Run explorers, send them across strange lands, collect gold and rare treasure, then upgrade the team's abilities.

Design read. The key lesson is strategic, not mechanical: a recognizable IP and a coherent fantasy do not guarantee durable service economics. Design the loop to remain satisfying with modest content cadence and avoid hard server dependence where possible.



MANAGEMENT TYCOON

Idle Miner Tycoon [S1]

4.7 stars | 857K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Open mines, upgrade shafts and transport, hire managers to automate the bottlenecks, then reinvest offline cash into the next mine or biome.

Design read. Best reference for legible automation and layered destinations. Its breadth, loot boxes and stacked offers are scale-team choices, not a solo-dev baseline.



SIMULATION INCREMENTAL

Egg, Inc. [S2]

4.8 stars | 559K US ratings | updated Jun 2026

Loop. Hatch chickens, expand habitats and shipping, research efficiency, fulfill contracts, then prestige into a more powerful farm.

Design read. A benchmark for visible world state. The number grows, but the farm visibly changes first - a stronger emotional reward than a dashboard balance alone.



PURE NUMBER TYCOON

AdVenture Capitalist [S3]

4.7 stars | 383K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Buy businesses, hire managers for automation, attract Angel Investors for permanent multipliers, and repeat the climb across themed worlds and events.

Design read. The cleanest skeleton in the set: buy, automate, prestige. Great pacing reference; weak reference for character attachment or social warmth.

Cozy worlds, short destinations and active verbs



COZY COLLECTION

Cats & Soup [S4]

4.9 stars | 339K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Add cooking stations, let cats produce resources while away, unlock recipes and facilities, then feed, dress and photograph the cast.

Design read. The strongest tonal comparator for Tickle the Pig. The return should feel like visiting a living place, not claiming a spreadsheet chest.



MICRO-TYCOON JOURNEY

Eatventure [S5]

4.8 stars | 78.5K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Open a food stand, buy stations, hire workers, automate service, finish the venue, then travel to the next restaurant and city.

Design read. Good proof that destinations can be the content ladder. The risk is letting gear, pets, clubs and passes outrun the simple restaurant fantasy.



ACTION-IDLE HYBRID

Idle Breaker [S6]

4.7 stars | 24.9K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Move through destructible spaces, break objects, loot materials, craft stronger tools, defend the shelter, and push into tougher zones.

Design read. Evidence that the market has hybridized: active verbs can acquire users, while automation and offline progress keep the idle promise. Active play should accelerate, not invalidate, away time.



DEEP EXPLORER ECONOMY

Idle Planet Miner [S7]

4.7 stars | 9,657 US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Unlock planets, mine ore, smelt and craft higher-value goods, hire managers, research upgrades, and react to markets and weekly tournaments.

Design read. Closest active reference to exploration plus idle management. Borrow the sense of route and discovery, but compress the resource chain so a player never needs a wiki.

Pure incrementals, idle RPGs and knowledge journeys



PURE INCREMENTAL

Revolution Idle [S8]

4.8 stars | 18.1K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Fill circles, multiply output, prestige, then unlock higher-order resets such as Infinity and Eternity plus automation and challenge layers.

Design read. A math-and-pacing benchmark. It proves theme is optional for incremental fans, but it is the wrong emotional north star for a character-led cozy game.



SOCIAL PRESTIGE RPG

Tap Titans 2 [S9]

4.8 stars | 82.5K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Tap through titans, recruit automated heroes and pets, tune a skill build, prestige for artifacts, then join clan raids, tournaments and seasons.

Design read. The proven source for pooled group-boss energy. For a four-pig Sounder, sum contributions and celebrate participation - never expose a shame ranking.



CHARACTER IDLE RPG

Legend of Slime [S10]

4.7 stars | 41.6K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Auto-battle stages, collect AFK loot, summon slimes and companions, upgrade gear and skills, and rotate through dungeons, events, PvP and alliances.

Design read. Strong evidence that warmth and combat can coexist. Also a warning: mode, currency and offer proliferation can make a cozy-looking game feel like an obligation stack.



KNOWLEDGE JOURNEY

Cell to Singularity [S11]

4.8 stars | 22.4K US ratings | updated Jul 2026

Loop. Tap for entropy, buy nodes on an evolution and technology tree, reveal 3D habitats, reset for metacurrency, and visit limited scientific simulations.

Design read. Best reference for making discovery the reward. A field guide or bestiary can turn progression into remembered places and creatures instead of currencies.

Six systems do most of the genre's retention work

The winning implementation is usually the smallest form that preserves the feeling.

1 Warm return

Away time resolves into a visible, itemized story.

Seen in: Cats & Soup, Planet Miner

TTP-sized form: Postcard: path, event, finds, next choice

2 Automation earned

Early friction becomes later convenience.

Seen in: Idle Miner, AdCap

TTP-sized form: Gear or friends automate a known task

3 Destination ladder

A new place refreshes the same verbs.

Seen in: Eatventure, Cell

TTP-sized form: Road chapters with one rule twist each

4 Scoped prestige

A reset makes the old wall feel small.

Seen in: Egg, Inc., Revolution

TTP-sized form: Prefer chapter clear or small Favor-like reset

5 Build verdict

One setup choice changes the next outcome.

Seen in: Planet Miner, Tap Titans

TTP-sized form: Three stats; enemy tells you why you stalled

6 Pooled social

Group progress creates an appointment.

Seen in: Tap Titans 2

TTP-sized form: Sounder sum, flat reward, no member ranking

The dominant stack sells time, certainty and recurring participation

Observed U.S. App Store IAP listings show a familiar ladder. Prices are snapshots and can change.

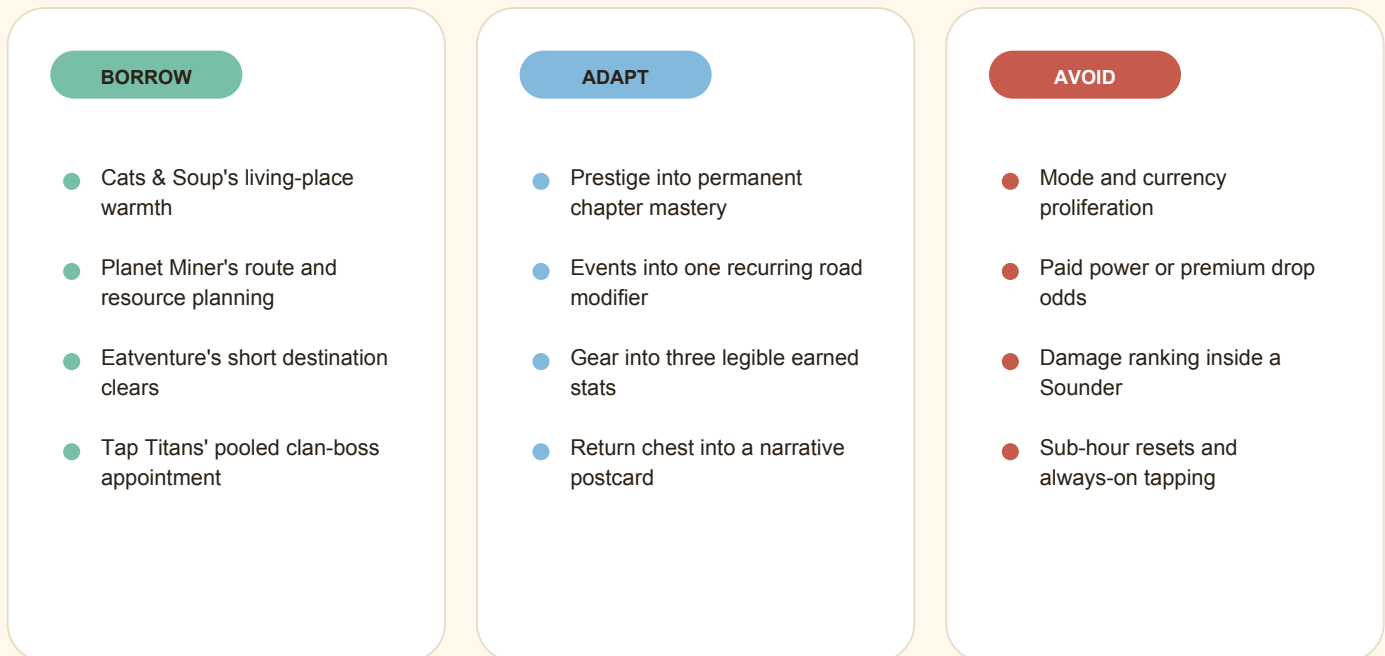
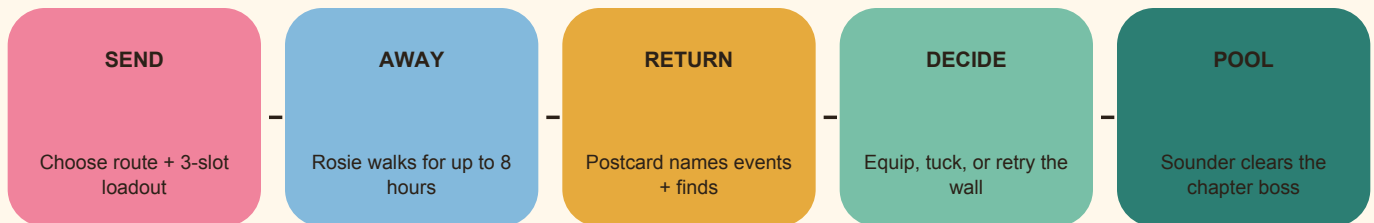
Permanent acceleration	Double cash, permanent boost, automation unlock	Idle Miner \$6.99 double cash; Eatventure \$5.39 permanent boost
Ad relief	Remove ads permanently or for a timed pass	Planet Miner \$9.99; Cats & Soup sells 7- and 30-day passes
Event participation	Season/event pass, premium reward track	Tap Titans \$9.99 season pass; Planet Miner \$14.99 Miner Pass
Currency + chests	Premium currency, loot, progress packs	Revolution ranges from \$0.99 to \$99.99; Idle Miner sells cash and chests
Membership	Recurring convenience and bonus income	Egg, Inc. ULTRA tiers; Legend of Slime \$9.99 membership

TTP FIREWALL

Recommended: keep expedition power earned in play. Slop Club and shop value can live in expression, additional narrative texture, cosmetics, or broad account convenience that does not decide a wall. Avoid: sold gear, premium drop odds, purchased Sounder contribution, or an offline-cap advantage. The market proves those tools monetize; TTP's differentiation is that it does not need them.

A TTP-sized idle loop: one road, one pig, one good decision

The goal is not to build a second game inside the game. It is to turn away-time into a story that strengthens Collect and Connect.



Design sentence: Send Rosie down a visible road, let time be kind to her, return to one memorable find, then make one choice that changes what happens next.

Test the emotional promise before building the content machine

A small prototype can answer the highest-risk questions without a migration, a new currency, or a live-service calendar.

1

Return ceremony
Show 3 versions: raw chest, itemized ledger, narrative postcard.

Success signal
Can players recall what happened and name the next choice?

2

Decision value
Give the same wall with two legible loadouts.

Success signal
Do players predict the result and change setup after a stall?

3

Away cadence
Simulate 1h, 4h and 8h returns with identical total value curves.

Success signal
Which interval feels generous without becoming forgettable?

4

Content compression
Run one chapter with 4 enemies, 6 gear pieces and one boss.

Success signal
Does depth come from combinations, or only from more content?

5

Sounder feeling
Compare pooled boss progress with a member damage list.

Success signal
Does pooled progress create a group-text moment without shame?

Instrument later: send-again rate after a return, return-claim completion, loadout changes after a stall, wall retries, distribution of away gaps, chapter-clear time, Sounder participation breadth, and whether the expedition displaces the Feeding heartbeat.

A directional product scan, not a market-sizing study

All store metadata and IAP examples are U.S. snapshots checked August 3, 2026. App Store rating counts can move and should not be read as MAU, downloads or revenue.

Method. The portfolio intentionally spans explorer/tycoon, cozy collection, action-idle, idle RPG and pure incremental designs. Mechanics and commercial signals come from first-party App Store descriptions and IAP listings; shutdown status comes from Imani. Interpretive statements are labeled as design reads. Icon artwork is displayed for identification via Apple's lookup response and remains the property of each publisher. [S13]

S0 Imani Studios - Temple Run: Idle Explorers shutdown notice

<https://imangistudios.zendesk.com/hc/en-us/articles/33459423693587-Temple-Run-Idle-Explorers-2023>

S1 Apple App Store - Idle Miner Tycoon

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-miner-tycoon-gold-digger/id1116645064>

S2 Apple App Store - Egg, Inc.

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/egg-inc/id993492744>

S3 Apple App Store - AdVenture Capitalist

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/adventure-capitalist-tycoon/id927006017>

S4 Apple App Store - Cats & Soup

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/cats-soup-relaxing-cozy-games/id1581431235>

S5 Apple App Store - Eatventure

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/eatventure/id1600871388>

S6 Apple App Store - Idle Breaker

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-breaker-zombie-survival/id6448195469>

S7 Apple App Store - Idle Planet Miner

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-planet-miner/id1441880123>

S8 Apple App Store - Revolution Idle

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/revolution-idle/id6475233313>

S9 Apple App Store - Tap Titans 2

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/tap-titans-2-hero-legends/id1120294802>

S10 Apple App Store - Legend of Slime

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/legend-of-slime-idle-rpg/id1618701110>

S11 Apple App Store - Cell to Singularity

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/cell-to-singularity-evolution/id1327555461>

S12 Apple App Store - Idle Explorer (distinct Madbox title)

<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-explorer/id1491737397>

S13 Apple iTunes Search API documentation

<https://developer.apple.com/library/archive/documentation/AudioVideo/Conceptual/iTuneSearchAPI/LookupExamples.html>

Internal fit assessment: CONTEXT.md; docs/idle-battler-genre-research.md; docs/expedition-idle-battler-plan.md; docs/expedition-v0-playable-spec.md.